flourishing centre complete with a gemstone industry. Beads in different stages of manufacture, discarded chips, raw material blocks, and a range of precious stones—sapphire, beryl, agate, carnelian, amethyst, lapis lazuli (probably from Badakshan), jasper, garnet, and soapstone—have been unearthed from habitations there. At Porunthal in the Amaravathi river valley of Tamil Nadu as well, beads of quartz, carnelian, and glass have been found in large quantities. The several hundred glass beads and a glass furnace found suggest production on a commercial scale.

An aspect of the present and the past juxtaposed in these inscriptions is the use of dramatic and effective rhetoric. In a passage redolent with metaphor, Ashoka suggests that the change could be charted through a transformation in sound: where war drums had once sounded the emperor was now ensuring the sounding of morality (‘bherighoso aho dhammaghoso’).[33] While in the past music had accompanied armed battles —the beating of the ‘bheri’ was a call to arms—there was now only the sound of dhamma being proclaimed. Rhythm and onomatopoeia were to be deployed to render the messages sonorous and effective. The enunciation in this set of edicts is marked by emphases placed at various points by the repetition of particular phrases. The message returns time and again to a contrast of past and present so that the effect of what Ashoka claimed as achievement was highlighted with each juxtaposition. The words ‘Formerly, in the ages gone by’, in particular, recur constantly for oratorical effect.

Among the more striking aspects of the major edicts is the emperor’s perception of himself as a sovereign spiritual guardian with social responsibilities. The seventh edict includes an impassioned plea for the practice of religious tolerance. It is the emperor’s wish, the edict says, that everywhere in his dominions all religious sects should live. Proto-secularism is a possible term for this desire, making the Ashokan link with the modern Indian state’s constitutional commitment to such values entirely logical. Ashoka also speaks of how he imagined ordinary folk should